



CASE STUDY | BAKERSFIELD CITY SCHOOL DISTRICT

Bakersfield City School District Turns to Survey Data to Launch Its Portrait of a Graduate

Bakersfield City School District partnered with Hanover research to develop a vision of student success with a Portrait of a Graduate that will inform its long-term strategic direction.



THE DISTRICT

Bakersfield City School District

LOCATION

Bakersfield, California

THE CHALLENGE

Gather comprehensive community feedback to build a common set of skills and competencies for all graduates

HANOVER SOLUTIONS

Surveys, Qualitative Analysis

[Bakersfield City School District](#) (BCSD) in California aims to uphold its mission to “educate all students at the highest levels of academic excellence to become collaborative, creative, and critical thinkers.” In 2023, the K-8 district partnered with Hanover as it developed its [Portrait of a Graduate](#) (POG) — a strategic, unified vision of the ideal skills and competencies of all BCSD graduates.

THE CHALLENGE: GATHER A COMMUNITY VISION OF GRADUATE SKILLS

Using Hanover’s [strategic planning toolkit](#) as a guide, BCSD formed an internal committee made up of teachers, administrators, and support staff to begin developing its Portrait of a Graduate. Essential to the process was methodically collecting feedback from all educational partners to identify and agree on the important characteristics, competencies, and skills its students should develop prior to graduation.

To achieve a unified vision, BCSD would need to build widespread community engagement, starting with large-scale survey research and analysis with over 7,000 sixth-eighth graders and their families. BCSD leaders sought Hanover’s research expertise to ensure they would not miss any vital insights or community buy-in opportunities.

“In 2023, we formed a committee of various stakeholders to engage in meaningful conversations and unify a collective framework to guide our students and district. Hanover’s ability to gather community feedback and reflect the findings back to the community was invaluable to our work.”

Mark Luque
Superintendent

THE SOLUTION: LEVERAGE SURVEY EXPERTISE AND INFOGRAPHICS TO REFLECT A COMPELLING POG

In March 2023, BCSD and Hanover launched a POG [survey to obtain feedback and perceptions](#) from middle school students, families, staff, and community members regarding the academic, cognitive, personal, and interpersonal characteristics, attributes, and qualities that district students should develop before graduation.

The Hanover team developed and launched the customized survey based on the unique goals and concerns of BCSD leadership. Next, they analyzed the data to identify patterns that illustrate a picture of success for the district. To ensure a comprehensive analysis of all collected data, Hanover's qualitative team analyzed the open-ended survey responses. The findings from the survey and the open-ended responses revealed insights on common themes and recommendations, including:

- **Respondents agreed students should graduate with robust social-emotional skills related to personal character, leadership, and community service.**
 - **Recommendation:** The district should create more opportunities for students to connect and collaborate with peers.
- **Staff and parents emphasized different aspects of college and career readiness.**
 - **Recommendation:** The district should consistently communicate students' expectations, core values, and desired outcomes.
- **Parents and staff agree that students would benefit from practical foundational skills, such as budgeting, nutrition, and technology.**
 - **Recommendation:** The district should engage families and community members in supporting students' post-secondary planning through multi-faceted efforts and partnerships.



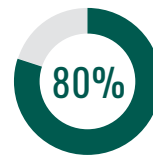
29,447

The number of students enrolled at BCSD



584

The number of survey respondents included in the analysis after data cleaning



The percentage of parents who believe a college education is important for workforce success, compared to 59% of staff

“I’ve worked with Hanover for nearly seven years, calling on their data expertise and ability to help us build capacity for important projects. Our Portrait of a Graduate needed to include the whole Bakersfield community to live up to its potential. Hanover helped ensure all perspectives had a voice.”

Mark Luque
Superintendent

THE OUTCOME: BCSD’S PORTRAIT OF A GRADUATE SETS A COURSE FOR A BETTER FUTURE

Based on the survey findings and conversations with the community, BCSD and Hanover distilled the desired skills and qualities for graduates into six core competencies that form the basis of the POG:

- **Communicator**
- **Collaborator**
- **Creator**
- **Critical Thinker**
- **Resilient Learner**
- **Problem Solver**

To share the POG with the community, BCSD and Hanover developed a series of communication infographics to represent each of the core competencies. BCSD also created a [web page](#) and videos to help the community feel invested in the collective

vision. These competencies now serve as guiding principles that district decision-makers can use to align student learning experiences and direct district strategy.

Moving forward, BCSD leaders will continue to implement changes that align with the POG to ensure graduates leave the district with the right skills for success in high school and their future careers.

BCSD continues its strategic partnership with Hanover on a variety of projects and initiatives, including an annual student climate survey and research on staff retention.